

MICRONESIA

Capital city: Palikir**Area:** 271 sq miles
(702 sq km)**Population:** 108,143

NAURU

Capital city: None**Area:** 8.1 sq miles
(21 sq km)**Population:** 12,570

PALAU

Capital city: Melekeok**Area:** 177 sq miles
(458 sq km)**Population:** 19,717

SOLOMON ISLANDS

Capital city: Honiara**Area:** 10,985 sq miles
(28,450 sq km)**Population:** 477,000

VANUATU

Capital city: Port Vila**Area:** 4,710 sq miles
(12,200 sq km)**Population:** 212,000

FIJI

Capital city: Suva**Area:** 7,054 sq miles
(18,270 sq km)**Population:** 839,000

TUVALU

Capital city: Fongafale**Area:** 10 sq miles
(26 sq km)**Population:** 11,305

TONGA

Capital city: Nuku'alofa**Area:** 289 sq miles
(748 sq km)**Population:** 108,141

SAMOA

Capital city: Apia**Area:** 1,137 sq miles
(2,944 sq km)**Population:** 178,000

KIRIBATI

Capital city: Bairiki**Area:** 313 sq miles
(811 sq km)**Population:** 98,549

MARSHALL ISLANDS

Capital city: Majuro**Area:** 70 sq miles
(181 sq km)**Population:** 56,429

THE PACIFIC OCEAN

THE WORLD'S LARGEST, DEEPEST OCEAN, the Pacific covers one-third of the Earth's surface, stretching from the shores of Asia and Australia to the Americas and Antarctica. About 20,000 volcanic and coral islands lie scattered over its vast expanse, many covered with lush vegetation. Over much of the Pacific the climate is hot and moist. The native island peoples, who originally came from Southeast Asia, fall into three main groups: Polynesians, Melanesians, and Micronesians. Europeans began to arrive in the 1500s, and by the 1800s many islands were colonies of powerful countries overseas. Today, some of the islands are self-governing; in others foreign control is still strong.

Coconut palms provide the islanders with food, milk, and fiber to make rope.

Large families of 10 or more live together under one roof.

PACIFIC PEOPLES

Some islanders live in towns, but many people continue the traditional farming way of life, growing crops such as yams and sweet potatoes, or fishing from the sea. The shape of homes varies from island to island but most, like this Fijian *bure*, are simply built using a large wooden frame topped with a thatch of plant fronds. Today, corrugated iron is often used as roofing because it lasts longer than thatch. Community life on the islands is important, with large extended families ruled by tribal chiefs. Property and personal objects belong to everybody.

People often keep chickens and pigs.

Men wear a cloth skirt called a *sulu*.

A special meal might include fish, chicken, yams, vegetables, coconut, and bananas.

Boys learn to weave using green coconut leaves.

This area of the house is used for guests.

EXPORTS

Rich, volcanic soil and regular rainfall make these hot, sunny islands especially fertile. Some farmers produce surplus crops that they export. Sugar, ginger, black pepper, and copra (dried coconut) are among the main export crops. Fish, lumber, livestock, and minerals are also important sources of income on certain islands.

The green fruit of the black pepper plant is dried to make black peppercorns.

Ground pepper



NUCLEAR TESTING

Since the first experiments at Bikini Atoll in 1946, the US, Britain, and France have used the Pacific to test nuclear weapons. The islanders and groups such as Greenpeace campaigned to stop the testing. France carried out the last explosions in 1996. A treaty banning tests was signed in 1998, but some islands are still not safe to live on due to high radiation levels.



THE EFFECT OF TOURISM

Many of the "island paradises" are fast becoming major tourist destinations – especially around Fiji, Tonga, and Samoa. Tourism brings in valuable income, but it can also damage the environment and affect the life of local people. For example, already limited water supplies may be diverted away from villages to hotel pools and showers.